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LAST WORD

I leave Indian cricket in safe hands. I have played with the current generation of cricketers who now constitute the core of the Indian team. Batting, I feel, will continue to be our strength and the current crop, which is a good mix of experience and youth, will surely play together for many years and serve the country with distinction. On the bowling side, while some of our bowlers are doing well, we need to find a few more talented fast bowlers. In the past we have had some really good bowling pairs, but what we need now is a bowling unit that will play for the team at the same time. This is a tough challenge, but with the depth of talent available in the country, I am sure we are up to it.

Finally, the game of cricket itself is extremely vibrant. Cricket is the only sport that has three distinctive formats and each format has a constituency of its own. While Test cricket will always remain the pinnacle, one-day international cricket too is in good shape, with the Champions Trophy and the fifty-over World Cup seeing tremendous support the world over. Also, Twenty20 continues to attract the youth, as shown by the popularity of the IPL.

A lot of people have asked me what I will be doing in the future. Frankly, I don’t know. When I started out playing cricket at eleven years of age I had no idea I would go on to play for India or would play 200 Test matches. All I knew was that I wanted to play the game well and enjoy every moment. I stayed in the moment and lived each situation as they came to me.

I had never thought there would come a time when I would not be able to go out for walks with my children, or take them shopping, that going